Mixed Signals

The aim to widen the broadcast coverage is commendable, but the ministry has to shed its 'controller' image

By Kaushik Deka

Anurag Thakur
Minister of Information & Broadcasting; Youth Affairs & Sports

IN ITS OWN WORDS, THE MINISTRY of Information and Broadcasting, now headed by Anurag Thakur, is entrusted with the task of disseminating information about government policies, schemes and programmes through the different mediums of mass communication. However, in the last few years, it has been embroiled in several controversies over 'control' of information—from showdowns with big tech companies to new laws reportedly aimed at censoring content on TV, digital and OTT platforms. Critics cried foul when the ministry formed a fact check unit, a TV channel was banned for allegedly hurting national security, and several YouTube channels got blocked intermittently. The truth, though, has other shades too. Watchdogs do raise valid concerns, but the government has its own reasons for keeping a hawk-eye on the ceaseless flow of information in this digital age.

Beyond these debates, the ministry took several positive steps: streamlining Prasar Bharti norms to make its functioning transparent; amending policy guidelines on the expansion of FM radio to generate employment opportunities and ensure its spread to remote areas; adding three laws of the ministry under the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2022, for decriminalisation; launching the Broadcast Seva Portal for speedy processing of broadcasters' applications; and preserving and digitising regional films. Recently, Amazon India signed a Letter of Engagement with the ministry for a multi-layered collaboration to promote creative talent, build capacity at existing institutes and platforms and construct a route to globally showcase 'Made in India' creative content. ■

BOLD & BRAVE

((FM))

Three amendments to the FM radio policy guidelines

20 MILLION

Listeners to be added to All India Radio network



1,50,000

DD FreeDish Set Top Boxes distributed in remote areas

BUT...



IT Rules 2021 from becoming a tool for censoring digital media

Amend the Cinematograph Act of 1952 to allow filmmakers to appeal against censorship